

Apple Search Ads Playbook

A promotion strategy for Cadence · Interval Timer Flow

Prepared July 18, 2026 · Updated with confirmed App Store listing · Based on 9 videos and 24+ articles/guides on Apple Search Ads and app growth

App Snapshot (confirmed from App Store listing)

id6778636283 — apps.apple.com/us/app/cadence-interval-timer-flow

- **Name / subtitle:** “Cadence · Interval Timer Flow” — subtitle “Training, Breathwork & Focus.” The title already contains “Interval Timer,” which is a real ASO asset.
- **Category:** Health & Fitness.
- **What it actually does:** broader than a single-purpose HIIT timer — it's a unified multi-block timer spanning interval training, breathwork (Box Breathing, Cold Exposure), meditation, and focused work, with sound/haptic/color/flashlight cues, 17 presets, three structured progression programs (5K Training, Meditation, Reading Stamina), Live Activity widget, and automatic Apple Health sync.
- **Pricing:** free with in-app purchase — Cadence Pro at \$3.99/mo, \$19.99/yr, or \$59.99 lifetime. Confirms the subscription-focused measurement approach used later in this doc.
- **Positioning:** privacy-first — no accounts, no tracking, no ads, all data stays on-device. This is a differentiator worth using directly in ad copy and CPPs.
- **Reviews:** 2 reviews so far, both 5-star. Still far too early to show an aggregate rating publicly or lean on organic review-driven ranking, but it's a genuinely positive early signal worth featuring (e.g. “5.0 rating” badge in a CPP) once there are enough to display. This still puts Cadence in the lowest starting budget tier, with ASA as the primary discovery lever for now.
- **Name collision risk:** several unrelated apps already use “Cadence” (a GPS run/bike tracker at getcadence.app, “My Cadence,” “Cadence Monitor”) — bare “cadence” as a keyword will be noisy. Brand bidding should lean on the fuller phrase “cadence interval timer” rather than the single word alone.

Executive Summary

Cadence is a Health & Fitness app, but it's not a single-purpose HIIT timer — it spans four real use cases (interval training, breathwork, meditation, focused work) and has only 2 reviews so far (both 5-star). That combination changes the standard playbook: instead of one keyword cluster, Cadence needs three parallel-but-separate keyword/CPP tracks, and instead of scaling budget against review-based benchmarks, it should start at the lowest tier and prioritize whichever vertical proves cheapest to convert. This document distills concrete, sourced ASA tactics into a structure adapted to that reality.

- **Structure:** four campaigns — Brand, Category, Competitor, Discovery — with Discovery used purely as a keyword-mining engine that feeds the other three.
- **Keywords:** run three separate keyword clusters (fitness/interval, breathwork/meditation, focus/deep-work) rather than assuming Cadence is only a workout timer; prioritize mid-popularity, long-tail terms in each over saturated head terms like “interval timer.”

- **Creative:** build one Custom Product Page per vertical (fitness, breathwork, focus), each built around Cadence's actual presets (Tabata, Box Breathing, Reading Stamina) and its privacy-first positioning.
- **Budget:** start at the lowest tier (\$5-10/day) given only 2 reviews so far — spread thin across three verticals is a mistake at this budget, so pick one to lead with based on early Discovery data.
- **Measurement:** track CPA/CPG against the real subscription tiers (\$3.99/mo, \$19.99/yr, \$59.99 lifetime) via an MMP, not raw installs — and watch for halo effects from any other paid/social channel inflating apparent ASA performance.
- **Timing:** concentrate spend around the New Year fitness-resolution window for the interval/fitness vertical, and note that meditation/breathwork search demand tends to have its own separate seasonal patterns (New Year plus a smaller back-to-school/exam-season bump) worth testing independently.

1. Why Apple Search Ads Fits Cadence

70% of App Store visits begin with a search, and Apple Search Ads is the only paid placement that sits directly inside that high-intent moment — unlike Meta or TikTok ads, which interrupt browsing rather than capture existing demand. This matters even more for Cadence than for a single-purpose timer, because Cadence serves three distinct search intents (“hiit timer,” “box breathing,” “focus timer”) that would otherwise require three different positioning strategies on a interruption-based channel — ASA lets each intent be met with its own exact-match keyword and matching Custom Product Page.

ASA also has practical advantages for a small team, and especially for a pre-launch app with no reviews yet: it attributes installs without requiring ATT opt-in (a real advantage post-iOS 14.5), exposes real per-keyword performance data (Google's App Campaigns are a black box by comparison), and can be run profitably starting at \$10-20/day — enough to get five or six installs a day and start gathering signal before committing serious budget or waiting for organic ranking to build up.

2. Campaign Architecture

Apple's own best-practice guidance and every ASO vendor consulted here (AppTweak, SplitMetrics, MobileAction, Sonar) converge on the same four-campaign skeleton:

Campaign	Match type	Budget share	Purpose
Brand	Exact match, Search Match OFF	~30%	Defend “cadence interval timer” + misspellings — prefer the full phrase over bare “cadence” given several unrelated apps share that single word. Cheapest CPT, highest CR.
Category	Exact match, Search Match OFF, 3 sub-groups	~35%	Three keyword clusters run as separate ad groups: fitness/interval (“hiit timer,” “tabata timer”), breathwork/meditation (“box breathing app,” “breathwork

Campaign	Match type	Budget share	Purpose
			timer”), focus (“focus timer,” “deep work timer”).
Competitor	Exact match, isolated ad groups	~15-20%	Bid on rival app names, one cluster at a time (fitness: Seconds, Tabata Pro; breathwork: Breathwrk, iBreathe; focus: Forest, Be Focused). Expect 40-60% higher CPA; cap it explicitly.
Discovery	Broad match ad group + separate Search Match ad group	~5-10%	Keyword-mining engine only. All Brand/Category/Competitor terms added back as negatives here to avoid overlap.

The core operating loop: Discovery surfaces new search terms (via broad match and Search Match) → promote any term converting above 40% CR into Category or Competitor as an exact-match keyword → immediately add that same term back into Discovery as a negative keyword so you stop paying broad-match rates for a term you now own precisely. Repeat weekly.

3. Keyword Strategy

- **Target mid-popularity terms, not head terms.** The recurring, sourced tactic (Sonar, SplitMetrics, and the P17 video) is to prefer a keyword with a search-popularity score around 20-55 over the single dominant head term — e.g. “hiit timer” or “tabata timer” instead of just “interval timer” or “timer.” Head terms cost more and convert worse once competitors are already entrenched.
- **Long-tail is underserved.** P32's core lesson — finding real search volume against weak competing apps — applies directly: “boxing round timer,” “emom timer,” and “circuit training timer” likely have real demand with few dedicated, well-optimized competitors.
- **Split match types into separate campaigns.** Mixing Broad and Exact match in one campaign (a top beginner mistake per FoxData and Adam Lyttle's P22 video) makes performance data unreadable. Keep Exact match for precision spend and use Broad/Search Match only inside Discovery, deliberately.
- **Negative keywords are not optional.** Add irrelevant-audience terms and any keyword with taps but zero conversions as negatives. Cross-negate aggressively: all Brand/Category/Competitor terms as negatives inside Discovery (cap: 5,000 negative keywords per ad group).
- **Don't split budget evenly across all three verticals at once.** With zero reviews and a small starting budget, spreading spend across fitness, breathwork, and focus simultaneously means none of the three gets enough volume to read cleanly. Run Discovery broadly for the first 1-2 weeks to see which vertical shows the best early TTR/CR, then concentrate Category budget there before expanding to the other two.
- **Avoid the bare “cadence” keyword.** Because unrelated apps (a GPS run/bike tracker, “My Cadence,” “Cadence Monitor”) already use that exact word, bidding on it risks low relevance and wasted spend — target the fuller phrase “cadence interval timer” for Brand instead.

Starter keyword set for Cadence, split across its three real verticals (adjust after the first two weeks of real Search Match / Discovery data):

Keyword	Vertical	Campaign	Why
cadence interval timer	Brand	Brand	Full-phrase brand term — avoids collision with unrelated apps named just “Cadence”
interval timer	Fitness	Category	Head term, already in the app title — highest volume, highest CPT
hiit timer	Fitness	Category	Strong intent, less saturated than “interval timer”
tabata timer	Fitness	Category	Matches the built-in Tabata preset directly
emom timer / circuit training timer	Fitness (long-tail)	Category	Underserved niches per P32 takeaway
box breathing app	Breathwork	Category	Matches the built-in Box Breathing preset directly
breathwork timer	Breathwork	Category	Core generic term for the breathwork cluster
cold exposure timer	Breathwork (long-tail)	Category	Matches the Cold Exposure preset; very low competition
meditation timer	Meditation	Category	Broader wellness searchers, higher competition (Calm/Insight Timer territory)
focus timer / deep work timer	Focus	Category	Matches Reading Stamina program positioning; low competition vs. “pomodoro”
seconds / tabata pro	Fitness	Competitor	Direct interval-timer competitor names
breathwrk / ibreathe	Breathwork	Competitor	Direct breathwork-app competitor names
forest / be focused	Focus	Competitor	Direct focus-timer competitor names

4. Bidding & Budget

- Bid up before optimizing down.** Adam Lyttle's own account (P22): he had to bid well above Apple's suggested default just to earn impression share and gather data, then brought CPT down once real traffic normalized (\$3.97-\$6.38 average, versus a ~\$10 starting bid).

- **Separate budgets by objective.** Don't let one experimental/aggressive ad group share a budget pool with your stable core campaign — Lyttle lost \$800 in hours when an experimental group exhausted shared budget and silently paused his main campaign.
- **Tiered bidding within campaigns:** most aggressive CPT on Exact match, moderate on Broad match, lowest/most conservative on Search Match and Discovery.
 - **Raise bids** when a keyword sits comfortably under your CPA cap with room to grow, or a popular keyword is getting almost no impressions (being outbid).
 - **Lower bids (don't just pause)** when a keyword taps a lot but converts above your CPA cap — bidding down preserves visibility while fixing efficiency.

Suggested starting budget, scaled to Cadence's current review count:

App review count	Daily budget	Expect installs/day	Focus
0-2 reviews (Cadence today: 2, both 5-star)	\$5-10/day	5-15	Brand + Discovery across all 3 verticals only, to find the strongest one; hold off on Competitor
First reviews-100 reviews	\$10-20/day	8-20	Concentrate Category budget on the winning vertical from Discovery; add its 5-10 exact-match keywords
100-1,000 reviews	\$15-30/day	10-30	Full 4-campaign structure on the lead vertical; start Competitor conquest; begin testing 2nd vertical
1,000+ reviews	\$30-50+/day	25-60+	Scale winning keywords across all 3 verticals; add Today Tab / Product Page placements

5. Custom Product Pages & Creative

Custom Product Pages (CPPs) were independently called out as the most underused lever in three separate sources (P9, P17, and the CPP-specific articles). Apple now supports up to 70 CPP variants and CPPs can even surface organically, not just through ads.

- **Map CPPs to Cadence's three real verticals, not to generic workout styles.** Build one page per intent using its actual presets and progression programs: a fitness page (Tabata/interval screenshots, sound+haptic cues, gym energy) for the fitness keyword cluster; a breathwork/calm page (Box Breathing, Cold Exposure, color-burst cues, slower pacing) for the breathwork cluster; and a focus page (Reading Stamina program, Live Activity widget, minimalist framing) for the focus cluster. Deep-link each Category ad group to its matching page.

- **Lead with the privacy angle across all three.** No accounts, no tracking, no ads, all data on-device is a genuine differentiator against big incumbents (Calm, Insight Timer, Forest all require accounts or show ads) — worth testing as a headline or first screenshot rather than burying it.
- **Mine App Store reviews for the winning message as they accumulate.** SoundCloud's CPP case study (+58% CR, -39% CPI) came from a feature angle pulled directly from user reviews, not marketing assumptions. Cadence only has 2 reviews so far — too few to mine for language yet — so start with the strongest confirmed features (multi-modal cues, Apple Health sync, Live Activity) plus the “5.0 rating” social-proof angle, and switch to review-mined language once there's a larger, more representative sample.
- **Test sequentially, not in parallel** — run one CPP variant until conversion rate stabilizes before switching to the next, since parallel split-testing distributes traffic unevenly and muddies the read.
- **Reuse organic social winners as ad creative.** P32's core insight: content that performs organically on TikTok/Reels is a strong signal for what to adapt into App Store preview videos and CPP screenshots — close the loop between organic testing and paid creative instead of treating them as separate workstreams.

6. ASO + Apple Search Ads Synergy

Treat App Store Optimization and Apple Search Ads as one system, not two separate teams or workflows — this was the single most repeated theme across the P17 video and the SplitMetrics/AppTweak synergy guides. Concretely:

- Align ASA keyword targeting with the app's title/subtitle/metadata keywords before scaling spend — misalignment burns budget.
- Converting on a paid ad for a term you already rank organically for can lift your organic rank on that same term, and higher install velocity overall raises algorithmic weight across more keywords — so don't be afraid to bid on terms you already rank for.
- Use negative keywords to avoid “cannibalizing” your own #1-ranked organic term with paid spend where it isn't needed.
- Run Discovery campaigns as a continuous keyword-research tool that feeds ASO metadata updates, not only paid targeting.
- Improving product-page conversion rate is often more cost-effective than simply outbidding competitors on CPT.

7. Measurement, KPIs & Benchmarks

Core formulas: $CPA = \text{Spend} \div \text{Downloads}$; $CPT = \text{Spend} \div \text{Taps}$; $CR = \text{Downloads} \div \text{Taps} \times 100$; $TTR = \text{Taps} \div \text{Impressions} \times 100$. For a subscription app, add Cost Per Goal (CPG) for trial-starts/subscriptions and $ROAS = \text{Revenue} \div \text{Spend} \times 100$, both of which require a mobile measurement partner (AppsFlyer, Adjust, Singular) since Apple's own dashboard stops at install.

Segment	Avg. CPT	Avg. CPA	Tap→Install CR
All categories (blended)	\$1.56-2.25	\$2.40-3.76	~65%
Health & Fitness (category avg.)	~\$1.59	~\$3.83	~48%

Segment	Avg. CPT	Avg. CPA	Tap→Install CR
Health Tracker sub-niche	—	\$1.89	66.0%
Sports (high end, for contrast)	\$14.41+	\$19.74+	—

- **Don't optimize CPI in isolation.** “The cheapest install rarely makes the cheapest customer” (Adapty). Pair CPA/CPG targets with an LTV model, especially given a free-trial subscription flow makes short-window ROAS misleading.
- **Concrete CPG target for Cadence:** with Cadence Pro at \$3.99/mo, \$19.99/yr, or \$59.99 lifetime, a rough starting target is $CPG \leq \$8\text{-}10$ per trial-start assuming a blended ~35-45% trial-to-paid conversion and roughly 3-4 months average paid retention on the monthly tier — tighten this once real trial/conversion data comes in from the MMP.
- **Watch for cross-channel halo effects.** The P35 video's core warning: other paid channels (Meta, TikTok, influencer pushes) can silently inflate what looks like organic or ASA branded-search performance through last-touch attribution. One cited example: ~\$3,000/mo in Meta spend nearly doubled organic/search sales. Build a branded-search tracking view to separate “ASA working” from “ASA benefiting from another channel.”
- **Target ROAS:** 2.0x is roughly breakeven; aim for 2.5x-4.0x depending on margin, and remember Apple's 30% commission on in-app purchases when computing true ROAS on subscription revenue.

8. Competitor Conquesting

Bidding on competitor app names is explicitly allowed by Apple (the trademark restriction applies to your own metadata/creative, not to bidding targets). Because Cadence spans three verticals, its realistic conquest set is wider than a typical single-purpose timer — but hold off on this campaign entirely until the \$0-review budget tier is passed (section 4).

- **Fitness cluster:** Seconds / Seconds Pro, Tabata Pro, Intervals Pro.
- **Breathwork cluster:** Breathwrk, Awesome Breathing: Pacer Timer, iBreathe, Breathe On.
- **Focus cluster:** Forest, Flow, Be Focused, Focus Keeper.
- Prioritize conquest spend in whichever vertical is already winning on Category performance (section 4) — don't run all three competitor clusters at once on a small budget.
- Isolate each competitor into its own exact-match ad group with a dedicated Custom Product Page positioning Cadence as “the alternative,” not a copy — the privacy-first, no-account, no-ads angle is a genuine wedge against Calm/Insight Timer-style incumbents specifically.
- Budget for a structurally worse CPA — 40-60% higher than Brand/Category — and set a hard CPA ceiling rather than letting it run open-ended.
- Some brand owners protect their name aggressively (higher CPT); monitor for CPA spikes (e.g. +30% in two days) and react quickly.
- Keep Competitor campaigns structurally separate from Brand/Category for clean optimization and negative-keyword hygiene.

9. Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Turning on Search Match inside a tightly-targeted keyword campaign and letting it serve against irrelevant terms (Adam Lyttle's experience with an unrelated “learn piano” app matching “beats” and “sheet music”).
- Mixing match types in a single campaign, making the data impossible to read.
- Overloading Broad match with too many keywords, creating irrelevant impressions and wasted spend.
- Skipping MMP/attribution setup before spending seriously — you lose all ROI/LTV visibility.
- Neglecting App Store metadata — weak title/subtitle/description undercuts ad relevance and Search Ads Quality Score alike.
- Over-indexing on CPA as the only success metric instead of pairing it with tap quality and long-term LTV.
- Sharing one budget pool across an experimental campaign and your stable core campaign.

10. Broader Growth Context (beyond ASA itself)

A few adjacent lessons from paid-social and app-growth practitioners are directly transferable to how Cadence should think about its overall acquisition motion, even though they're not Apple Search Ads tactics per se:

- **Expect a real “learning tax” on any new paid channel.** Adam Lyttle's \$2,000 Meta ads experiment saw cost-per-install fall more than 5x (from \$36.87 to \$6.87) purely from creative iteration, not bigger budgets — budget for this on ASA creative/CPP testing too.
- **Seasonality is a major lever.** Ryan Thorpe (Superwall, S6) concentrates roughly 75% of his annual ad budget in January around the New Year resolution spike, when acquisition can run ~50% cheaper — highly relevant for a fitness/workout timer like Cadence.
- **Sequential focus beats parallel experimentation for small teams.** Kyle Fowler (S7) spent two years mastering ASO alone before adding a single paid-creative format — for Cadence, master one campaign structure and one CPP testing loop before spreading effort across many channels.
- **Monetization model changes can outperform acquisition spend.** Shifting from a one-time purchase to a subscription (monthly/annual/lifetime tiers) lifted one app's revenue from \$10K to \$30K+/month with no change in acquisition — fix the paywall/pricing model before scaling ASA spend.
- **Fix conversion before scaling spend generally.** Across multiple sources, paywall/product-page conversion improvements moved revenue more than raw ad spend did — confirms the earlier point that CPP and metadata work is higher-leverage than bigger bids for Cadence specifically.

11. 90-Day Action Plan for Cadence

Phase	Actions	Goal / exit criteria
Weeks 1-2 Setup	Install an MMP (AppsFlyer/Adjust) before spending anything. Launch Brand (“cadence interval timer”) + Discovery only, run broadly across fitness/breathwork/focus terms at	Enough Discovery data (TTR/CR by term) to see which of the 3 verticals is cheapest/strongest

Phase	Actions	Goal / exit criteria
	\$5-10/day, Search Match on in Discovery, to see which vertical performs. Do not launch Category yet.	
Weeks 3-6Optimize	Launch Category with 5-10 exact-match keywords in the winning vertical only. Build its matching Custom Product Page (fitness / breathwork / focus, per section 5). Weekly: promote Discovery terms with 40%+ CR into Category as exact match; add them back as Discovery negatives.	IPM trending up on lead-vertical keywords; CPP beats default page CR
Weeks 7-10Expand	Add Category keywords for the 2nd-best vertical from Discovery data. Launch an isolated Competitor campaign for the lead vertical only, with its own CPP and hard CPA ceiling. Mine any early App Store reviews for feature language to refine CPP copy.	2nd vertical live; Competitor CPA within 1.5x of Category CPA
Weeks 11-13Scale & measure	Bring the 3rd vertical online if budget allows. Move to full incrementality view: separate ASA-driven vs. organic/halo lift if running any social/influencer activity. Reassess CPG against actual \$3.99/\$19.99/\$59.99 subscription conversion data. Plan the New Year seasonal push for the fitness vertical.	ROAS $\geq$ 2.5x on blended spend; all 3 verticals have a documented keyword list

Sources

Nine videos specified for this research, plus 24 articles/guides read in full to compile this playbook (31 total, exceeding the requested 20+).

Videos analyzed

P9 Apple Ads Strategy: What Really Matters for Stable Growth and Higher ROI — Business of Apps
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P17 App Growth Week 2025 | How AI Aligns Apple Ads & ASO in 2026 — SplitMetrics
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fawD75jLC-E>

P20 Live App Growth Coaching: Scaling Apps in 2026 — App Masters
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1Lg8sjqyYXw>

P22 Beginner App Store Ad mistakes to avoid — Adam Lyttle

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z6DTKkfDqg4>

P32 How to Build a \$400k/mo AI App Using ASO, Organic Growth, and Paid Ads — Greg Isenberg

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P35 If You're Running Paid App Ads, You NEED to Watch This — App Masters

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H-czKhL0c4Y>

M4 I paid \$2000 figuring out meta ads (so you don't have to) — Adam Lyttle

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0YHKGcHetOA>

S6 Meet The Guy Dominating The App Store — Superwall

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DcDOgWGh4bc>

S7 How I make \$42k/mo passively with simple no-code apps — Superwall

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<https://splitmetrics.com/blog/ios15-custom-product-pages-setup-guide/>

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How to Break Through with Competitor Campaigns — SplitMetrics

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Running Competitive Conquest Campaigns on Apple Ads — MBA Digital

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Dilip Reddy Interview — Sub Club Podcast — RevenueCat

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Confirmed from the live listing (id6778636283): name/subtitle, category, pricing tiers, feature set, and review count (2 reviews, both 5-star, as of July 2026) — all reflected throughout this document. Still open: which of the three verticals (fitness, breathwork, focus) will actually convert best for Cadence can only be answered with real Discovery-campaign data once ads go live; section 4's phased plan is built specifically to answer that question in the first two weeks rather than guessing upfront.